

# CMPT 230 AS01

## Hollow Knight Analysis

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## **Introduction: Game Selection - Stefan Cvijovic**

Hollow Knight, a 2D-Platformer Metroidvania developed by indie game company Team Cherry, is a tightly tuned package which delivers in all of the aspects presented by the games it's influenced by. Following the established "metroidvania" design, Hollow Knight takes the non-linear gameplay and progression systems prominent in games like Metroid and Castlevania: Symphony of the Night and executes the ideas presented in them to remarkable similarity and just as much quality - especially considering the small size of the development team. As is typical in the genre, the player explores a non-linear world - one full of bugs and towering vistas which vastly outscale the player character in size - and progressively gets stronger as they explore further into "Hallownest." The player will encounter numerous NPCs who'll impart information about the world around you, find new power ups which make your character more nimble and powerful, and much more. Part of the reason we selected this game was not only because multiple of us have played it to completion (and for some, multiple times) but also because, despite Hollow Knight building its gameplay and design off previous titles and inspirations, the developers did so while accomplishing it with great originality in ideas as well as its high quality in its execution. In the following sections, we will discuss various aspects of Hollow Knight as an entity, spanning from gameplay design/mechanics, audio and visuals, lore and narrative, as well as player experience along with its impact on the indie game industry.

## **Gameplay Analysis - Zhire Pelayo**

Hollow Knight's core gameplay encompasses a souls-like difficulty combat sprinkled with platforming and metroidvania elements. Metroidvania is a game genre where players can't access a specific area until they acquire particular items, forcing them to go back to older areas. You play as the Knight, with seemingly no goal but to descend a once prosperous kingdom called Hallownest. The map is massive and filled with various regions, secrets, and lore to uncover. The game's combat starts straightforward with only a slash attack, but as you progress through the game, you unlock new spells and abilities to add to your arsenal, which adds more depth to the combat. The player also possesses a soul bar, gradually building up as you hit enemies. This resource is used to either heal during combat or cast abilities, which adds another depth to the gameplay as it forces the player to play defensively or offensively. The players are also eventually introduced to charms, which are items that players can equip to grant various bonuses and combat options.

Furthermore, as you descend further into the level, you will eventually encounter bosses who act as an obstacle preventing the players from progressing. They force the player to adapt and master the game mechanics in order to prepare them for exploring the deeper parts of

Hallownest. The boss mechanics and their difficulty are why many consider the game a souls-like. A souls-like is a genre of game where the player is expected to die repeatedly due to its notoriously high difficulty. In a sense, the players themselves progress as they naturally improve at playing the game. But as any game does, bosses grant rewards such as geo, which is the primary currency of the game, which lets them purchase items and upgrades, but upon death, players lose their gathered geo. But worry not; if players return to their place of death, they will encounter a shade-like enemy that grants them back their geo once defeated.

As previously mentioned, one of Hollow Knight's primary focus is platforming and exploration. As you descend deeper into Hallownest, you encounter areas that seem unreachable initially, but as you progress, you gain the needed skills and abilities to explore them. This is where the metroidvania element of the game comes in. As you play through the game, players might encounter walls that may look too high at first, but the player is eventually introduced to an item called the Mantis Claw, which lets the player traverse the impossible. This adds a layer of complexity regarding navigation and incentivizes the player to return to previously inaccessible older areas because they might contain upgrades to aid the player in their journey.

Hallownest is a multi-layered kingdom where levels feel distinct, but the world is seamlessly interconnected. Level progression varies from different players as it is highly dependent on exploration. This gives players a sense of discovery, which keeps them hooked and engaged. The game eventually introduces the player to fast travel, which lets them explore levels with ease. The game also does an excellent job of creating a sense of mystery without relying on traditional storytelling through meticulously crafted levels. For instance, the player will eventually stumble upon relics of the past, such as an area called the City of Tears. The City of Tears is a majestic, ruined city filled with broken structures, giving the player a peak of what Hallownest once was.

In conclusion, Hollow Knight's core gameplay consists of combat, exploration, and progression. The game fully immerses the player in its steep but rewarding learning curve in terms of combat. The level design is sprawling with life and lore, encouraging the player to explore further to uncover its mysterious world. Hollow Knight's progression includes upgrades but also rewards the player's perseverance and willingness to improve. The sense of progression, from mastering combat to unlocking new areas, is what makes Hollow Knight a truly remarkable and unforgettable experience, leaving the player with feelings of accomplishment.

## Visuals and Audio - Eli Born

Hollow Knight presents a 2D make belief world where it combines both audio and art to create not just experiences but emotions with every trudge in your journey in the game. Upon launching the game you are greeted immediately with a dark color scheme with mysteriously ominous but peaceful music. It tells the user that this game is going to be one of in depth story, along with some darker undertones. Enter the game and you find your playable character interacting with everything it touches, the rubble on the ground, the slashing of their weapon which creates a visual flare accompanied by a light swinging noise. Visually the art is like looking at a moving painting, it combines many foreground and background elements to the atmosphere along with a slight third dimension of audio and sound effects; when entering the game some creatures fly off the foreground of the screen, being able to hear the flaps of their wings much louder. The first tutorial area has little to no music but a lot of audio. The user may not consciously notice this but you can hear the footsteps of your character, the sounds of enemies walking and aggroing onto the player. The audio effects are engaging and listening for new ones or specific ones becomes more of a reward rather than a task. You soon learn that the grounds in the game are prone to breaking, dust appears, rocks crumble and the loud booming noises of the rocks breaking and falling taught me what to avoid and what to look for.

Upon finishing the tutorial and reaching your first village a sense of serene calmness befalls the player as bellowing but calming wind is accompanied by a peaceful tune, everytime I arrived in dirtmouth; the first village, it felt calming and I knew there would be no enemies in this safe zone. Three important visual main points of the game come to life here; light, Benches and signs. White light acts as a sort of visual guide without reading text to progress in the game by showing available pathways to take. Benches are safe zones for players to heal. Signposts are direct hints to get to a safezone. I was consistently looking for these types of visual settings in the game, this assisted me instead of running around aimlessly into walls to find paths and secrets. To more casual players this teaches them that they aim to reach these points to explore the world further. Additionally you can't always see objects or pathways to advance to. In most cases this means that audio will be your ally here. In exploration audio was the perfect idea of getting the player's curiosity and forces them to seek out the audio that plays. An example of this is the grubs that are hidden throughout the land, they do a consistent soft cry that alerts players one is nearby. If you free one it expresses joy and runs off. However if you leave without freeing it, the grub gets sad and returns to doing the same cry. Both audios of the joy and cry targets both groups of characters that wish to just explore and play the game, enticing them to save the critters and for those who wish to complete the game or gain resources it saves the player a lot of time. Even if players aren't a fan of bugs, Hollow Knight has made them exceptionally cute to show they aren't an enemy, however due to the difficulty and unfairness this isn't always the case. A lot of the enemies can or may have cute noises or look defenseless but pose immense threats, often leaving the character stunted by the choices to kill them.

It is no exaggeration that the entire game is full of life, all of the biomes have a unique color scheme and completely different music. Even if the area wasn't as enjoyable as the last, the reward for traversing to a new area after exploring for new paths felt extremely rewarding and was easy to differentiate due to the change in atmosphere by the art and music.. Everything you interact with will almost always produce some sound or show visual damage. NPCs that are deemed useful have a lot of emotion and yet produce no understandable language in terms of audio. Grunts and babbles still differentiate characters between them, bosses take this important role for the player to learn their audio and visual cues on when they will attack the player. The vast sizes and color differences between all of the NPCS in the game made my experience so immersive. My character made no noises at all, showed no emotion but throughout most of my time playing it I didn't notice as I was feeling the reward or satisfaction of finding or helping an important NPC for the character.

Hollow Knight as a whole shows all of its strengths and nearly none of its weaknesses on a casual run of the game. Accessibility for players is great as the maps are color coded to the main color of each region and every room feels unique to one another. Ideally I wanted to play the game to its fullest but after getting every essential map in the game, it would visually gave hints right on the map to some paths you may have missed but to actually get everything achievable some parts of the map are directly cut off and show no hint or idea that there might be something there. Later you gain a map of certain collectables, in which some of those might be off the map in secret areas. Not all were obvious and something I would avoid having in my games.. Having very hard to obtain secrets without some sort of hint system much like they did with audio of shining items emitting a higher pitched noise or better visual identifications like previously mentioned to have a better mapping out system, running around aimlessly didn't feel fun especially without a more accessible quick travel system.

The audio is completely immersive, repeated sounds aren't redundant and are oftentimes assist the player and new sounds often come as a new thing to discover.

## Narrative and Storytelling - James Dwyer

Hollow Knight begins with a cutscene that includes text and visuals that introduce the player to the game's world and the plot's atmosphere without explicitly stating the game's story. Throughout the game, the plot is not directly given to the player; it is shown and pieced together through dialogue with numerous NPCs, cutscenes, various visual elements, and entries in the hunter's journal. The hunter's journal is an in-game item that adds notes and bits of lore based on an enemy the player has defeated. The overall gameplay revolves around the Kingdom of Hollownest and the Knight, who the player plays. The game also has different endings the player can achieve, allowing the player to learn and explore the plot of Hollow Knight. The story begins with the Knight entering Dirtmouth, which rests upon the fallen kingdom of Hollownest and is the start of the Knight's journey to defeat the dreamers and the seal with the Radiance inside and get rid of the infection that brought upon the ruin of Hollownest.

The kingdom of Hollownest was founded by the Pale King, a higher being who ruled with his queen, the White Lady. The kingdom of Hollownest flourished under his reign until the "infection" happened. The infection was brought upon when the Radiance, a higher being like the Pale king, was no longer worshipped and forgotten and attempted to make the bugs of the world of Hollow Knight remember her through dreams. This attempt did not prove successful and allowed for the manifestation of the "infection," which gave its subjects heightened strength but also caused madness. The Pale King, in an effort to stop the spread of the "infection," sealed away the Radiance in a "Vessel with no mind nor will," which were the children of the Pale King and the White lady, and the vessel chosen was the Hollow Knight. The Pale King sealed away the Hollow Knight and the Radiance, but after some time, the Hollow Knight was not a "pure vessel," causing the "infection" to reappear and cause the fall of the Kingdom of Hollownest. This fall of the kingdom brings us to the beginning of the game "Hollow Knight," when the player enters Dirtmouth on the quest to stop the infection and the Radiance.

In wilds beyond they speak your name with reverence and regret,  
For none could tame our savage souls yet you the challenge met,  
Under palest watch, you taught, we changed, base instincts were redeemed,  
A world you gave to bug and beast as they had never dreamed.

- FROM 'ELEGY FOR HALLOWNEST' BY MONOMON THE TEACHER

Upon starting the game, the player is introduced to the Elegy for Hollownest by Monomon, the Teacher, an NPC in the lore involved in the knight's quest to

stop the infection.

This is the first occurrence the player has with the story of the game and the first mention of other characters. The world of Hollow Knight has numerous NPCs that give bits of information about the premise of the world and the game, and many that also directly aid the player with in-game items and information that help to progress through the game. The

numerous NPCs and information they provide demonstrate the world's vastness and allow for a greater sense of immersion from the player when traversing the world and story, generating a more complex and enjoyable experience for the users playing the game. The world's plot also directly impacts the player, as the setting of the world and the gameplay as the Knight on a quest to defeat the “infection” directs the player's actions and course of events and progression through the story. As stated previously, a player can achieve multiple endings in the game with different endings to the knight's tale and outcomes. This demonstrates the player's impact on the world and allows an even higher level of immersion the user can have. The world of Hollow Knight portrays potentially several themes and messages. One of the themes being that there is the theme of dreams, where the infection initially began with the Radiance's attempt at regaining followers, as well as the dream realm, which appears in the game and at various points in the story, as well as the “dreamers” that were sealed away with the Hollow Knight and the Radiance.

Hollow Knight is a complex and vast story covering many NPCs, groups of NPCs, and numerous characters and an expansive world delivered to the player through immersive environments, in-game bits of lore, and dialogues with many of the characters in the game. The story guides the player and allows for a more enjoyable experience due to the possibility of making your ending what you want to complete in the world out of the five selected endings of the game. The world of Hollow Knight allows the player to draw many themes and messages from the game due to the expansive world-building, the plot progression, and the world around the player as they progress through the many areas the game offers. One of the most vital strengths of Hollow Knight as a game is its ability to communicate the plot without directly explaining each detail about the plot and characters while also containing an expansive and engaging world.

## **Player Experience and Industry Impact - Stefan Cvijovic**

Back in February of 2017, Hollow Knight launched on PC storepages to relative success, and later next year launched on modern consoles. Many critics and reviewers alike praised it for being a masterclass in game design, boasting numerous claims of being “one of the best metroidvanias<sup>1</sup>” in the market at the time. With many games in previous years coming out with their own takes at the genre - like Ori and the Blind Forest, Axiom Verge and Guacamelee - it was clear that Hollow Knight was not simply another typical game added to the pile. Hollow Knight's success not only brought more eyes into the metroidvania genre and indie game market, but also brought various “clones” into existence - one example being Lotus Knight, a 2D metroidvania slated to come out in 2024 which takes *heavy* inspiration from Hollow Knight itself, leaning moreso towards genuine copying of design choices and ideas rather than true inspiration.<sup>2</sup> Taking these few examples into account, it would be remiss to discount Hollow Knight's impact in specifically the indie game industry.

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<sup>1</sup> Destructoid Review on HK

<sup>2</sup> Lotus Knight Steam page

Pivoting away from the larger-scope discussion of Hollow Knight's impact to more closely look at the individual gamer's experience with the game, we find that many consider Hollow Knight to be an "unashamedly challenging" yet rewarding game, presenting varying ordeals that the player must overcome in order to progress further into the game.<sup>3</sup> A large part of the difficulty found in Hollow Knight comes from what many players consider to be "soulslike" design - design choices and ideas commonly found in FromSoftware's "Dark Souls" series. There are many design choices present in the game that contribute to said conceptions of the game's difficulty, including but not limited to: aggressive enemy AI, an intentional focus on tighter, more challenging platforming, and a rather punishing death system reminiscent of Dark Souls' death system, where you lose your currency on death and have to tread back to your body to retrieve it. Some players may get frustrated when faced with such obstacles, and others may take them as a challenge to overcome which will grant them satisfaction or rewards in-game - either viewpoint is completely valid, and is certainly expected with a game that has significant difficulty and a learning curve.

Another aspect of the player experience (not related to the subjective difficulty of the game), is the player interacting with the gameplay loop of reaching new areas, reaching a wall and "getting lost." In the world of Hallownest, the map is vast and winding, and if you don't know where to get tools to keep track of your character, you can easily spend hours finding your way to the next progression point in the game. As is seen with the critical acclaim Hollow Knight continues to receive post-launch, gamers certainly enjoy this game loop. The world of Hollow Knight is immersive; you're shoved into this tightly-woven kingdom with a beautiful score, great art and visuals, tightly-tuned controls and satisfying combat, and with enemies boasting rather complex ai-combat patterns which make it as engaging to play as it is fun to explore.

As a player, your gameplay motivation moving through Hallownest is, in rough order, find new areas, find areas you can't necessarily access, obtain abilities to allow you access to blocked areas, and then explore previously inaccessible areas. This process effectively repeats until the end of the game. Not considering gameplay motivation, you also have motivation to related to the underlying story, with bits and pieces of lore being shown to you at a time - an incomplete puzzle where you can piece together the story as you go along. Depending on if you're the kind of player who enjoys a challenge, you have a plethora of different enemies and boss fights you're able to fight and defeat, each with different rewards to make you stronger in game. If you're the kind of player who likes to dig into the game's deep lore and worldbuilding, the time and care has most certainly been put into place by the developers to allow such a motivation from a player to exist.

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<sup>3</sup> IGN Review on HK

## References and Resources

### Resources:

 The (Mostly) Complete Lore of Hollow Knight

 Hollow Knight - Release Trailer

 Hollow Knight OST - Enter Hallownest

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